V2.0 — 2026 · STABLE

Design System

A unified token, component, content, and governance system for web, app, software, and slide contexts. All monospace, warm parchment, minimal — across light and dark.

IBM Plex Mono | Warm parchment | Light + dark | WCAG AA | Multi-platform

00 — FOUNDATIONS

Principles

Six rules. Every token, component, and pattern in this system is downstream of these. When something feels off, check whether it violates one of them — usually it does.

01

Meaning over decoration

Color, weight, and motion exist to encode meaning, never to ornament. A red border means failure; an accent color means active. If it doesn't say something, it shouldn't be there.

02

Monospace as identity

One typeface. Hierarchy comes from weight, size, and spacing — not from font variety. The all-mono stack is non-negotiable; it's what makes the system recognizable across web, slides, and print.

03

Warmth over contrast

No pure black, no pure white. Every surface holds warmth. Elevation is expressed through tonal shifts in the parchment, not drop shadows or hard contrast.

04

Functional motion

Animation reveals state — focus, transition, dismissal. Never decorative bounce, never delay over 250ms. One easing curve throughout. Reduced-motion preferences are honored at the token level.

05

One way to do a thing

If two components could be used for the same job, only one is correct. The component catalogue is small on purpose. Adding variants requires governance — see Governance.

06

Accessible by default

All token pairings meet WCAG AA contrast. Focus is always visible. Motion is reducible. Touch targets are at least 44px. Components ship accessible — there is no "a11y pass" later.

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01 — FOUNDATIONS

Colors

A warm sepia palette. No pure black or white — every surface has warmth. Colors encode meaning, not decoration.

Base palette

--bg	--bg-subtle	--bg-surface	--bg-overlay
#f7f3eb	#f0ead9	#ede6d6	#e6dcc8

--fg
#2c1f0e

--muted
#9a7f5e

--faint
#c4a882

--accent
#b8882a

--border
#d9c8a9

--border-strong
#c4a882

Semantic colors

Used to encode meaning — critical for SRE contexts (incidents, degraded, healthy, informational).

SUCCESS
Healthy, resolved, passing. Uptime, green deploys.

WARNING
Degraded, elevated latency, approaching threshold.

DANGER
Incident, outage, failed check, critical alert.

INFO
Informational, in progress, neutral notice.

Token reference

TOKEN	VALUE	USAGE
--bg	#f7f3eb	Page / slide background
--bg-subtle	#f0ead9	Sidebar, nav, alternate rows
--bg-surface	#ede6d6	Cards, inputs, code blocks
--bg-overlay	#e6dcc8	Modals, popovers, tooltips
--fg	#2c1f0e	Primary text, headings, icons
--muted	#9a7f5e	Secondary text, labels, placeholders
--faint	#c4a882	Disabled, very muted hints
--accent	#b8882a	Links, hover, active, highlight
--border	#d9c8a9	Default dividers, card borders
--border-strong	#c4a882	Input borders, emphasis borders

01 — FOUNDATIONS

Typography

IBM Plex Mono exclusively. The all-monospace stack is the identity — do not deviate. Structure comes from weight, size, and spacing, not font variety.

Web type scale

HERO / TAGLINE
1.15rem · 400 · ls -0.01em
max-width 52ch

Building reliability into every system.

PAGE TITLE
1.80rem · 500 · ls -0.02em

Design System

POST TITLE
1.10rem · 500 · ls -0.01em
max-width 52ch

On building observable systems without friction

BODY TEXT 0.90rem · 400 · lh 1.75	Reliability is not a feature you add at the end. It is a discipline embedded in every decision, from schema design to deployment frequency. The SRE practice makes that discipline explicit.
SECTION HEADING 0.78rem · 500 · uppercase ls 0.08em · --muted	01 — FOUNDATIONS
NAV / LABEL 0.80rem · 400 · ls 0.04em	Color · Typography · Spacing · Grid
CAPTION / META 0.75rem · 400 · --muted	2025-06-12 · 4 min read · sre, observability
BLOCKQUOTE 0.82rem · italic · --muted 2px left border	> *"Hope is not a strategy. Reliability engineering is."*
CODE INLINE 0.88em · bg-surface 1px border · accent	Use `--accent` for interactive elements and `--danger` for error states.
KEYBOARD xs · bg-surface · border	Press `⌘` + `K` to open command palette.

Code block

```
// token usage example
const theme = {
  bg:      '#f7f3eb',
  fg:      '#2c1f0e',
  accent:  '#b8882a',
  danger:  '#8b2e2e',
  success: '#3a6b3a',
};
```

01 — FOUNDATIONS

Iconography

Icons are text-glyph or thin-stroke SVG. No filled icons, no multi-color. They sit on the typographic baseline and inherit color from `currentColor`.

Glyph set — common icons

Mono glyphs cover most UI needs without an SVG sprite. Use `↗` for external links, `↑↓` for trends, arrows for navigation, dots and bars for state.

↗ external	↑ trend-up	↓ trend-down	→ forward	← back	· separator	+ add	× close	⌘ cmd	⏎ return
✓ check	● dot								

SVG style

Stroke	1.25px, round caps, round joins. Never filled.
Grid	16 × 16 viewBox. Optical center on the cap-height axis.
Color	Always `currentColor` — never hard-coded hex.
Size	1em (matches its containing text). 14px / 18px / 24px concrete sizes; never in between.
Naming	kebab-case, action-first: `arrow-right`, not `right-arrow`.
Decorative vs meaningful	Decorative icons get `aria-hidden="true"`. Meaningful icons get `role="img"` + `aria-label`.

01 — FOUNDATIONS

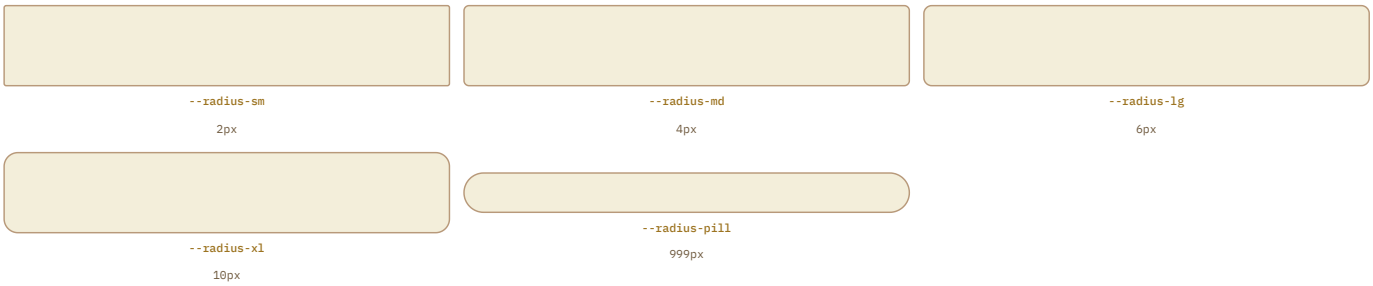
Spacing

A stepped scale. Use named tokens, never arbitrary values. Consistency in spacing is what makes a layout feel intentional.

01 — FOUNDATIONS

Radius & shape

Five steps. Most components use `--radius-sm` (2px) or `--radius-md` (4px). Soft corners are reserved for surfaces that float — popovers, modals — and pills.



Where each radius applies

--radius-sm	Buttons, inputs, badges, tags, chips, code inline, table cells.
--radius-md	Cards, alerts, toasts, dropdown menus, modal headers, code blocks.
--radius-lg	Modals, large feature cards, image containers.
--radius-xl	Hero sections, image lockups. Use sparingly — defaults to over-soft.
--radius-pill	Toggles, segmented controls, status pills, theme switcher.

Shadows (overlays only)

Surfaces flush with the page never carry a shadow — their elevation is signaled by tonal background only. Floating surfaces (dropdown, modal, toast) use a soft shadow tinted in the page's foreground color, never neutral grey.

--shadow-overlay	Dropdowns, popovers, autocomplete results.
--shadow-modal	Modal dialogs, sheets, full-screen overlays.
--shadow-toast	Toast notifications, snackbars.

01 — FOUNDATIONS

Surfaces & Elevation

Elevation is expressed through background warmth, not shadows. Deeper surfaces are darker parchment tones.

surface-1
#f7f3eb
Page background, base layer

surface-2
#f0ead9
Sidebar, alternate rows, subtle cards

surface-3
#ede6d6
Cards, inputs, raised components

surface-4
#e6dcc8
Modals, dropdowns, overlays

01 — FOUNDATIONS

Grid & breakpoints

CSS Grid throughout. Four named breakpoints — mobile-first. Layout decisions land at `md` (768px) and `lg` (1024px); rarely beyond.

Breakpoints

--bp-sm		≥ 480px
--bp-md		≥ 768px
--bp-lg		≥ 1024px
--bp-xl		≥ 1280px

sm — phones landscape	Stack to single column. Sidebar collapses behind a menu trigger.
md — tablet / small laptop	Reveal multi-column layouts (2-col, sidebar). Default content max-width 720px.
lg — laptop / desktop	Three-column dashboards. Persistent sidebar. Content max-width 860px.
xl — wide desktop	Allow 4-column grids. Avoid stretching prose > 80ch.

Column presets

1 column

full width

2 columns

col 1

col 2

3 columns

col 1	col 2	col 3

4 columns

col 1	col 2	col 3	col 4

Sidebar layout (7rem + 1fr)

date / label	content

01 — FOUNDATIONS

Motion

Transitions are functional, not decorative. Minimal, consistent, fast. One easing curve throughout.

--duration-fast		100ms · hover, icon color
--duration-base		150ms · border, background
--duration-slow		250ms · progress, expand
--ease	cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)	Standard ease-in-out

01 — FOUNDATIONS

Theming

The system ships in light and dark. Components consume tokens, not hex — switching themes is a single attribute change. Use the toggle at the top of this page to see every section re-skin live.

Activation

```
// 1. Default — follows OS preference automatically
<html> <!-- prefers-color-scheme handles it -->

// 2. Force light or dark
<html data-theme="light">
<html data-theme="dark">

// 3. JS toggle
document.documentElement.dataset.theme =
  document.documentElement.dataset.theme === 'dark' ? 'light' : 'dark';
```

Token contract

Every token has a value in both themes. Components must reference tokens (`var(--fg)`) — never raw hex. This is the single rule that makes theming reliable.

--bg → --fg	Page → ink. Inverts across themes; always > 11:1 contrast.
--bg-subtle … --bg-overlay	Elevation steps. Each darkens (light theme) or lightens (dark theme) by ~5% lightness.
--accent	Light: `#b8882a` · Dark: `#d8a85c`. Brightened in dark to maintain perceived saturation.
Semantic (success/warning/danger/info)	Hue preserved across themes; lightness adjusted to maintain ≥ 4.5:1 against the surface they sit on.
--shadow-*	Light: warm-foreground tinted at low alpha. Dark: pure black at higher alpha — parchment shadows disappear on dark surfaces.

Authoring rules

DO

`color: var(--fg);`

References a token. Re-themes automatically and never drifts.

DON'T

`color: #2c1f0e;`

Hex pinned to one theme. Looks fine in light, invisible in dark.

DO

Test every component in both themes during review. Dark mode is not optional.

DON'T

Use a different layout, density, or radius in dark mode. Theming changes color only.

02 — FOUNDATIONS

Accessibility

WCAG 2.2 AA is the floor, not a goal. Every token pair, focus state, motion preference, and touch target in this system has been chosen with this in mind. Components ship accessible — there is no "a11y pass" later.

Contrast — light theme

All token pairs used for body text or actionable elements meet AA (≥ 4.5:1 for body, ≥ 3:1 for large / non-text).

--fg on --bg	11.92:1	AAA
--muted on --bg	4.62:1	AA
--accent on --bg	4.51:1	AA
--danger on --bg	7.18:1	AAA
--success on --bg	5.06:1	AA
--faint on --bg	2.41:1	decorative only

Focus state

Every interactive element shows a 2px `--accent` outline with 2px offset on keyboard focus. Mouse focus is suppressed. Focus is never removed without a replacement.

FOCUSED (KEYBOARD)

Run deploy View logs

UNFOCUSED

Run deploy View logs

Keyboard navigation

`Tab` / `Shift`+`Tab`	Move forward / backward through interactive elements in DOM order.
`Enter` / `Space`	Activate buttons, submit forms, toggle expanded state on disclosures.
`Esc`	Close modals, dropdowns, popovers, toasts. Always dismisses overlays.
`↑` / `↓`	Move within lists: dropdown items, autocomplete options, radio groups.
`←` / `→`	Move within tabs and segmented controls. Update selection on move.
`Home` / `End`	Jump to first / last item in a list, tab strip, or pagination control.
`⌘`+`K`	Open command palette (when present in the app shell).

Touch targets

Minimum 44 × 44px hit area for any interactive element on touch surfaces — even when the visible component is smaller. Use invisible padding to expand the target without changing the visual size. The token `--touch-min` is the source of truth.

Reduced motion

When the user has set `prefers-reduced-motion: reduce`, all transitions and animations collapse to 0.001ms. This is wired globally — components don't need to handle it individually. Skeletons stop shimmering, toasts appear without sliding, smooth-scroll becomes instant.

Screen reader guidance

Decorative icons	`aria-hidden="true"`. They mustn't reach the screen reader.
Meaningful icons	`role="img"` + `aria-label="…"` with a literal description, not a metaphor.
Buttons that are icon-only	Always have `aria-label`. The visible glyph is not announced.
Live regions (toasts, alerts)	`role="status"` for non-urgent, `role="alert"` for incidents.
Form inputs	Always paired with a `<label>`; never rely on placeholder as label.
Headings	One `h1` per page. Don't skip levels — heading order is the screen reader's table of contents.
Color alone	Never the sole signal. Pair with text, icon, or position. A red dot is not enough.

Forms — error association

Inputs in error state set `aria-invalid="true"` and link to their hint via `aria-describedby`. The hint text shifts to `--danger` and stays in the DOM after the error clears, so screen readers don't lose track of the message.

```
<label for="threshold">Threshold (ms)</label>
<input id="threshold" aria-invalid="true" aria-describedby="threshold-hint">
<div id="threshold-hint" class="input-hint">Must be a number between 0 and 60000.</div>
```

Skip links

Every page with a persistent sidebar includes a "Skip to main content" link as the first focusable element. It is visually hidden until focused. This is non-negotiable for keyboard-only users on data-dense layouts.

Buttons

Four variants. No gradients, no shadows. Interaction through border and background change only.

PRIMARY

Run deploy Disabled

SECONDARY

View logs Export

GHOST

Cancel Learn more →

DANGER

Rollback Delete service

---

02 — COMPONENTS

Inputs

Monospace inputs feel native to the system. Focus expressed via border darkening only — no glow.

TEXT INPUT

SERVICE NAME

api-gateway-prod

Lowercase, hyphens only.

ERROR STATE

THRESHOLD (MS)

abc

Must be a number between 0 and 60000.

TEXTAREA

POSTMORTEM SUMMARY

Describe the incident...

SELECT

ENVIRONMENT

production

Form controls

Selection, toggles, and ranges. Same monospace identity as text inputs — interaction expressed through fill change, never glow.

RADIO GROUP

- (●) P0 — Page incident commander
- ( ) P1 — Notify on-call
- ( ) P2 — Open ticket only

TOGGLE / SWITCH

- Auto-rollback on SLO breach [on]
- Page secondary on-call [off]
- Quiet hours (22:00–06:00) [on]

SEGMENTED CONTROL

1h | 24h | 7d | 30d

SLIDER

Latency threshold 2400 ms

0 ms — 5000 ms

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02 — COMPONENTS

Badges & Tags

Badges encode status. Tags are user-applied labels. Both are small, flat, border-defined.

Badges

default | active | healthy | degraded | incident | in progress

Tags

sre | observability | reliability | kubernetes | oncall

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02 — COMPONENTS

Alerts & Toasts

Alerts persist in-page until dismissed by state change. Toasts are transient — they appear in a corner, auto-dismiss after a few seconds, and never carry destructive actions.

Alerts (persistent, in-flow)

INFO Deployment scheduled for 03:00 UTC. Expected downtime: 0s with rolling update.

OK All services nominal. SLO compliance at 99.97% over the last 30 days.

WARN Error budget for checkout-service is 42% consumed with 18 days remaining in the window.

CRIT P0 incident active — payment-service latency p99 exceeding 4000ms. Incident commander assigned.

Toasts (transient, corner-anchored)

OK **Deployment succeeded**
api-gateway-prod · v1.42.0 · 2m 14s

··· **Saving silence rule**
2-hour silence on payment-service alerts

WARN **Connection unstable**
Retrying — last attempt 4s ago

FAIL **Could not save changes**
Unauthorized — session expired

When to use which

ALERT

Persistent state the user needs to acknowledge or that affects their next decision (open incident, error budget low, deployment in flight).

TOAST

Confirmation of a transient action the user just took (saved, copied, exported, sent). Auto-dismiss after 4–6s.

NEVER TOAST

Critical errors that require action (use a modal or alert), confirmation prompts (use a dialog), or anything the user cannot recover from after dismissal.

NEVER ALERT

Routine "saved" confirmations — don't sit a banner in the page for a 2-second message. That's what toasts exist for.

02 — COMPONENTS

Stat cards

Large numbers for dashboards, slide callouts, and executive summaries. One metric per card.

99.97%
UPTIME · 30D
↑ 0.02% vs last period

42%
ERROR BUDGET USED
18 days remaining

1.2ms
P50 LATENCY
↓ 0.3ms improvement

02 — COMPONENTS

Lists

The journal-style date + content grid. Used for post indexes, changelogs, run logs.

2025-06-12	On designing for failure — lessons from three years on-call
2025-05-28	SLO as a conversation, not a contract

2025-04-14	Postmortem culture: what blameless actually means in practice
2025-03-02	A minimal observability stack that scales

02 — COMPONENTS

Tables

Dense, scannable, monospaced. Right-align numbers; tabular figures keep columns aligned. No alternating row colors — borders only. Headers uppercase and muted.

SERVICE	STATUS	P50	P99	ERROR RATE	OWNER
api-gateway-prod	healthy	12 ms	84 ms	0.01%	platform
payment-service	incident	42 ms	4120 ms	2.4%	checkout
checkout-service	degraded	38 ms	920 ms	0.18%	checkout
search-indexer	healthy	61 ms	240 ms	0.00%	discovery

Rules

RULE Right-align all numeric columns. Use `font-variant-numeric: tabular-nums` so digits stay vertically aligned.

RULE No zebra striping. The mono grid + borders is enough — alternating fills add visual noise without aiding scan.

RULE Sortable columns get an arrow glyph next to the header label, in `--muted`. Active sort uses `--fg`.

RULE For tables > 10 rows, sticky the header. For tables > 100 rows, virtualize.

02 — COMPONENTS

Avatars

Circle, mono initials. No photos in the system itself — photos are app-level content. Three sizes: 20px, 28px (default), 40px.

SIZES

CD CD CD

STACK — COLLABORATORS

CD RW JS +4

IN CONTEXT — ASSIGNMENT

RW assigned to Rosa Wei · 2h ago

WITH STATUS

CD

02 — COMPONENTS

Navigation

Top nav for the app shell. Tabs for in-page section switching. Breadcrumbs for hierarchical wayfinding. Pagination for paged lists.

Top nav

acme.sre Services Incidents Runbooks Postmortems Settings ⌘ K CD

Tabs

Overview Metrics Logs Traces Settings

Active tab: 2px `--accent` underline. Hover lifts text to `--fg`. Arrow-key navigation moves focus and selection.

Breadcrumbs

Services / checkout / payment-service / Incident #4128

Pagination

← 1 2 3 4 … 42 →

Overlays

Floating surfaces that sit above the page: dropdowns, popovers, modals. They use `--bg-overlay`, soft shadow, and trap focus when modal.

Dropdown menu

View on Grafana ⌘ G
Open runbook ⌘ R
Silence alert… ⌘ S
Copy service URL ⌘ C
Rollback deploy… ⌘ ⇧ R

Modal dialog

Roll back payment-service? ×

This will revert payment-service from v1.42.0 to v1.41.3. Current traffic will failover to the previous version within ~30 seconds. The deploy log entry will be marked as rolled-back.

Cancel | Roll back

Modals trap focus, dismiss on `Esc`, and return focus to the trigger on close. Destructive actions (rollback, delete) name the consequence in the title and require an explicit verb on the button — never "OK".

Z-index layering

`--z-base`	1 — page content default.
`--z-sticky`	100 — sticky headers, sidebar.
`--z-dropdown`	200 — menus, autocomplete results.
`--z-overlay`	300 — modal backdrop / scrim.
`--z-modal`	400 — modal dialog.
`--z-toast`	500 — toasts (above modals).
`--z-tooltip`	600 — tooltips (above everything).

02 — COMPONENTS

Feedback & State

Progress indicators, checkboxes, tooltips — all functional-first.

PROGRESS BARS

Error budget 42%
Deployment progress 78%
Disk usage 91%

CHECKBOXES

- [x] Runbook updated
- [x] Postmortem drafted
- [ ] Action items assigned
- [ ] Follow-up scheduled

TOOLTIP (HOVER BUTTONS)

View metrics Silence alert

CARD SURFACES

surface-1 — base card

surface-2 — subtle card

surface-3 — raised card

SKELETON LOADING

Use only after a request exceeds 250ms. Below that, just render the content directly — flicker is worse than wait.

ACCORDION

Why was the rollback delayed? ×

The on-call rotation handover happened mid-incident. The new IC needed to verify the rollback target before triggering it. Net delay: 4m 12s.

What detection should have fired earlier? +

Were customer-facing errors observed? +

03 — PATTERNS

Layouts & states

Components answer "what does a button look like." Patterns answer "what does a sign-up screen look like." These are the recurring page-level compositions — they reuse components and cite specific spacing.

Empty state

No incidents in the last 30 days

When a P1 or P2 fires, it will appear here with an assigned commander, severity, and resolution timeline.

Configure detectors

Empty states do three things, in order: explain what would appear here, explain why nothing's there yet, offer a path forward. Never just say "No data."

Error state — page-level

×

Could not load incident timeline

The metrics service returned an error.
This usually clears within 30 seconds.
If it persists, the upstream is degraded.

Retry View status page →

Loading state

Skeletons mirror the shape of the content they're replacing. Don't show a generic spinner where structure can be implied — predicting layout is what makes loading feel fast.

Form layout

Create silence rule

Suppress alerts matching these labels for the chosen duration.

SERVICE LABEL

payment-service

REASON

Deploying v1.42.1 — silence p99 alerts during rollout

Visible to your on-call rotation in the audit log.

DURATION

15m | 2h | 4h | 12h

Notify channel on expiry

Cancel Create silence

Single column. Labels above inputs. Submit on the right, cancel on its left as ghost. Group related fields with horizontal rules, never with boxes-within-boxes.

Page anatomy — dashboard template

acme.sre · Services · payment-service CD

payment-service

degraded checkout · v1.42.0 · deployed 2h ago

Silence View runbook Rollback

Overview | Metrics | Logs | Traces

99.21%
UPTIME · 30D

4120ms
P99 · LAST 5M

68%
ERROR BUDGET USED

Top: chrome (breadcrumb, identity). Header: title, metadata, primary actions on the right. Tabs split by concern. Body opens with key metrics, then drills into details below the fold.

Density variants

All patterns ship at default density. Compact density (used in dashboards, tables > 200 rows) reduces vertical padding by one step on the spacing scale — never by hand-tuned pixel values. Comfortable density (used in marketing, onboarding) increases vertical padding by one step. Density never changes radius, color, or font-size.

04 — IDENTITY

Voice & content

A design system without a voice produces inconsistent products. The visual system is monospace and minimal; the writing should match. Direct, technical, and respectful of the reader's time.

Voice — four traits

A

Direct

No hedging. "This will delete the table" instead of "Please note that this action may delete the table." If the action is destructive, say so plainly.

B

Technical, not jargon

Use the precise term when it exists ("p99 latency," "error budget"). Skip marketing words ("seamless," "powerful," "cutting-edge"). The reader knows what good software looks like.

C

Calm in incident

When something fails, the copy stays neutral. "Could not save" — not "Oops!" or "Something went wrong." Panic is the system's job to suppress, not to spread.

D

Respectful of time

Every word earns its place. If a sentence can be cut without losing meaning, cut it. Help text is for facts the user needs — never for friendly chatter.

Capitalization & punctuation

Sentence case	Buttons, labels, titles, menu items. `Run deploy` — not `Run Deploy`.
UPPERCASE	Section labels (8pt+, with letter-spacing). Brand wordmarks. Status badges.
No trailing punctuation	Buttons, labels, headings, bullet lists. Hint text and full sentences in body copy keep periods.
Em dashes	Use the typographic em dash (—), not double hyphens. Surround with spaces.
Numbers	Numerals always for measurements (2 ms, 99.97%, 14 services). Spell out "one" only in narrative prose.
Time	24-hour clock with timezone abbreviation: `03:00 UTC`. Never `3am`.
Dates	ISO format in tables and metadata: `2026-04-25`. "Apr 25, 2026" only in prose.

Microcopy — buttons

DO

Verb + object: `Run deploy`, `Save runbook`, `Roll back`. The button says what happens when it's pressed.

DON'T

`OK`, `Submit`, `Done`. These are placeholders, not actions. They tell the user nothing about consequence.

DO

Confirm the destructive action by name: `Delete service`, not `Yes, I'm sure`.

DON'T

Use exclamation marks. Ever. Not in buttons, not in toasts, not in alerts. The system isn't excited.

Microcopy — error messages

An error message has three jobs: name what failed, explain why (briefly), tell the user what to do next. In that order.

DO

`Could not save runbook — session expired. Sign in again to retry.`

DON'T

`Error 401`. The user doesn't read HTTP. Translate.

DO

`Threshold must be a number between 0 and 60000.` States the constraint.

DON'T

`Invalid input.` Doesn't say which input or what's wrong.

Terminology dictionary

Pick one term, use it everywhere. Inconsistency is the enemy of trust.

service	Always "service," never "app," "microservice," or "API" when referring to a deployable unit.
deploy	Verb and noun. Not "release," "rollout," or "push."
incident	P0/P1/P2 events. Not "outage," "issue," or "problem" in product copy.
silence	The act of suppressing alerts. Not "mute" or "snooze."
on-call	Hyphenated, lowercase. Not "oncall" or "On Call."
runbook	One word. Not "run book" or "playbook."
postmortem	One word, no hyphen. Not "post-mortem."
SLO / SLA / SLI	Always uppercase, no periods. Define on first use in user-facing copy.

Internationalization

Strings live in a flat key-value catalogue, never inline. Reserve 30% extra width for German, 50% for Russian. Avoid concatenating sentence fragments — translators need full sentences for grammar agreement. Date and number formatting always go through `Intl.*` — never hand-rolled.

Brand

The brand is the wordmark, the typeface, and the parchment palette. There is no logomark — the system is type-led on purpose.

Wordmark

design.system

on light surface

design.system

on dark surface

IBM Plex Mono, weight 500, tracking 0.06em, lowercase. The dot is the only ornament — always in `--accent`. Never use a different separator, never bold the period, never replace it with an icon.

Clear space & sizing

Clear space	Minimum 1× the cap-height on all sides. Nothing — including text — enters this zone.
Minimum size — digital	10px cap-height. Below this, the dot becomes ambiguous. Use the wordmark only above.
Minimum size — print	2.5mm cap-height.
Maximum size	None — the wordmark is always set to flow with body type, never as a hero element.

Misuse

DON'T

Set the wordmark in any font other than IBM Plex Mono.

DON'T

Apply gradients, shadows, outlines, or 3D effects.

DON'T

Capitalize. Title case kills the identity.

DON'T

Re-color the dot. It is always `--accent` in both themes.

Imagery & illustration

The system uses no decorative imagery. Photographs, illustrations, and stock graphics are out of scope. The visual identity is type, color, and grid — full stop. Diagrams and charts are the only acceptable graphical content; they follow the parchment palette and Plex Mono labels, never decorative styling.

Governance

A design system is a contract between teams. These rules describe how the contract is changed, who can change it, and how consumers are notified.

Versioning

Semantic versioning. The token catalogue is the public contract — breaking it bumps the major version.

MAJOR (x.0.0)	Token renamed or removed; component public API changed; any visible regression. Migration guide required.
MINOR (1.x.0)	New token, new component, new variant. Backwards-compatible visual refinement. No migration needed.
PATCH (1.0.x)	Bug fixes, accessibility fixes, doc-only changes. Always safe to upgrade.

Contribution flow

1. Open an RFC issue with the proposed change, the problem it solves, and three candidate designs.
2. Discuss in the weekly system review. Decisions are recorded in the issue, not in chat.
3. If approved, implement on a feature branch. Update tokens, components, docs, and the changelog in one PR.
4. Run the visual diff suite. Any unexpected diff is a blocker until acknowledged or fixed.
5. Maintainer review focuses on: naming, accessibility, theming parity, doc completeness.
6. On merge, a release is cut automatically. Consumers are notified via the release feed.

Deprecation policy

Marking	Add a `@deprecated` annotation on the token / component, plus a console warning in dev builds.
Soak window	Minimum two minor versions or 90 days, whichever is longer, before removal.
Migration path	Every deprecation must name its replacement and link to a codemod or migration recipe.
Removal	In the next MAJOR version after the soak window ends. Listed in the changelog under `REMOVED` .

Ownership

Maintainers	Two named owners. Approve all RFCs and merges. Rotate yearly.
Contributors	Anyone in the engineering org. Must follow the contribution flow above.
Consumers	Product teams. May not patch components in-app — bugs go through the contribution flow.
Office hours	Thursdays 14:00–15:00 UTC. Open Q&A, design feedback, RFC walkthroughs.

Release cadence

Patch releases ship as soon as merged. Minor releases batch every two weeks on Tuesdays at 10:00 UTC. Major releases are scheduled with at least 30 days notice and accompanied by a written migration guide. Releases never go out on Fridays.

Changelog

A reverse-chronological record of every visible change.
The entries here are illustrative — the live changelog is generated from PR labels at release time.

2.0.0 — 2026-04-25 — `major`

- ADDED Dark theme with full token parity. Activated via `data-theme="dark"` or auto via `prefers-color-scheme`.
- ADDED Accessibility section with contrast ratios, focus states, keyboard nav, reduced-motion.
- ADDED Components: tables, avatars, tabs, breadcrumbs, pagination, top nav, dropdown, modal, toast, skeleton, accordion, radio, switch, segmented, slider.
- ADDED Patterns section with empty / error / loading / form / dashboard templates.
- ADDED Voice & content guidelines, brand wordmark spec, governance & changelog.
- ADDED Tokens: `--radius-xl`, `--radius-pill`, `--shadow-overlay/modal/toast`, `--focus-ring`, `--bp-*`, `--z-*`, `--touch-min`, `--ease-in/out`.
- CHANGED Sidebar navigation reorganized into Start / Foundations / Components / Patterns / Identity / Operations / Slides.

1.2.0 — 2026-02-10 — `minor`

- ADDED Slide layout catalogue with 8 named layouts (TITLE, EXEC_SUMMARY, SECTION, TWO_COL, STAT, TIMELINE, RECOMMENDATION, CLOSING).
- ADDED Google Slides theme color slot mapping.
- FIXED Stat card delta indicator alignment when no unit is present.

1.1.0 — 2025-11-04 — `minor`

- ADDED Stat cards, journal-style lists, tooltip component.
- CHANGED Border tokens split into `--border` and `--border-strong`.
- FIXED Code block contrast in semantic alert backgrounds.

1.0.0 — 2025-08-01 — `initial`

- ADDED Initial token catalogue: parchment palette, IBM Plex Mono type scale, spacing scale, radius, motion, surfaces.
- ADDED Components: buttons, inputs, badges, alerts, cards, blockquote, code.

03 — SLIDES

Slides specification

The slides system is implemented in Google Slides via Apps Script — not in HTML/CSS. This section is a written specification: the source of truth that the master template and component scripts are built from.

Canvas & units

PROPERTY	VALUE	NOTES
Slide size	25.4 × 14.29 cm	Standard widescreen 16:9. Set in File → Page setup.
Safe zone margin	1.2 cm all sides	No content outside this boundary. Header and footer bands sit within it.
Header band height	1.0 cm	Top of slide. Contains brand name left, deck meta right.
Footer band height	0.7 cm	Bottom of slide. Contains source left, slide number right.
Content area top	2.4 cm from top	Below header band + insight title zone.
Insight title zone	1.2 cm → 2.2 cm	Reserved row below header for the governing thought. Always present on content slides.
Column gutter	0.5 cm	Gap between columns in multi-column layouts.

Type scale (Google Slides — points)

Google Slides uses points (pt), not pixels. Font is IBM Plex Mono throughout — import via Google Fonts in the master. All body text is left-aligned. Titles are left-aligned. Never center body copy.

ROLE	SIZE	WEIGHT	COLOR TOKEN	USAGE
insight-title	22 pt	500	--fg	The governing thought. One per slide. Max 2 lines.
section-header	13 pt	500	--muted	Column labels, subsection titles. Uppercase, ls 0.08em.
body	11 pt	400	--fg	Bullet points, paragraph text, table cells.
stat-value	36 pt	500	--fg or semantic	Large callout numbers. One metric per card.
stat-label	8 pt	400	--muted	Metric name below stat-value. Uppercase.
caption	8 pt	400	--muted	Annotations, chart axis labels, callout text.
footer	7 pt	400	--muted	Source citation (left) and slide number (right). Always present.
header-brand	7 pt	500	--bg on dark / --muted on light	Name/brand in header band. Uppercase, ls 0.10em.

Google Slides theme color mapping

Google Slides provides 10 theme color slots in the master. Mapping them correctly means one hex change updates the entire deck. Slots are named here by their function, not by the default Google names.

SLOT	GOOGLE NAME	MAPS TO	HEX	USED FOR
1	Dark 1	--fg	#2c1f0e	Primary text, header band background, title slide bg
2	Light 1	--bg	#f7f3eb	Slide background, text on dark surfaces
3	Dark 2	--muted	#9a7f5e	Secondary text, labels, section headers
4	Light 2	--bg-subtle	#f0ead9	Card fills, stat card backgrounds, section divider bg
5	Accent 1	--accent	#b8882a	Accent rule on section dividers, active highlights
6	Accent 2	--success	#3a6b3a	Healthy, resolved, on-target indicators
7	Accent 3	--warning	#b8882a	Degraded, at-risk, approaching threshold
8	Accent 4	--danger	#8b2e2e	Incident, outage, failed, critical
9	Accent 5	--info	#2e5c8b	Informational, in-progress, neutral callout
10	Accent 6	--border	#d9c8a9	Divider lines, table borders, card strokes

03 — SLIDES

Content rules

Rules for what goes on a slide and how it is written. These are as important as visual rules — a well-designed slide with a bad title is still a bad slide.

The insight title rule

NO Topic title: "Latency analysis" — describes what the slide is about, not what it means.

YES Insight title: "p99 latency has tripled since the June 10 deploy" — states the finding directly.

The title is the message. A reader who only reads the titles of every slide should understand the full argument of the deck. This is the Pyramid Principle applied to slides.

Structural rules

RULE One governing thought per slide. If a second point is needed, create a second slide.

RULE Every number on a slide must have a source. Source goes in the footer left, at 7pt, prefixed with "Source:".

RULE Slide number appears in the footer right on every slide including title and closing slides.

RULE Confidentiality label ("Confidential" or "Internal") appears in the footer left on every slide. Precedes the source if both are present, separated by " · ".

RULE Never use more than 3 levels of hierarchy on a single slide. If depth is needed, split into multiple slides.

RULE Bullet points are sentence fragments, not full sentences. No ending punctuation. Max 8 words per bullet.

RULE Maximum 5 bullet points per column. If more are needed, consider a table or a different layout.

RULE Charts and diagrams always have a title (the insight, not the chart type) and a source. Axis labels use the caption type (8pt).

Color usage rules

RULE Color encodes meaning, not decoration. Never use --success, --warning, --danger, or --info for aesthetic reasons alone.

RULE --success (#3a6b3a) = healthy, on target, resolved, passing. Use for SLO met, incident resolved, test green.

RULE --warning (#b8882a) = degraded, at risk, approaching limit. Use for error budget < 50%, elevated latency, soft threshold breach.

RULE --danger (#8b2e2e) = incident, outage, failed, critical. Use for P0/P1 active, SLO breached, hard threshold exceeded.

RULE --info (#2e5c8b) = neutral informational, in progress, planned. Use for upcoming changes, non-urgent notices.

RULE --accent (#b8882a) is reserved for structural decoration only: section divider rule, active nav marker. Never for data encoding.

RULE On dark backgrounds (title slide, closing slide), body text uses --bg (#f7f3eb), secondary text uses --muted (#9a7f5e).

Header & footer spec

ZONE	LEFT CONTENT	RIGHT CONTENT	BACKGROUND
Header band	Brand name — uppercase, 7pt, 500 weight, ls 0.10em	Deck name · Month Year — 7pt, muted	--fg (#2c1f0e) on content slides. Transparent on title/closing.
Footer band	Confidential · Source: [origin] — 7pt, muted	Slide number — 7pt, muted	Transparent always. Separated from content by 1pt --border rule.

03 — SLIDES

Layout catalogue

Eight named layouts defined in the Google Slides master. Each layout has a fixed name used by the Apps Script to reference and instantiate it. Layouts are described here — not mocked up — because the actual implementation lives in the master file.

LAYOUT_TITLE `title slide`

Use once — first slide of every deck

CONTENT FIELDS

- `deck_title` — main headline, 22pt, --bg, max 2 lines
- `deck_subtitle` — context line, 11pt, --muted
- `author` — name, 7pt, --muted, uppercase
- `date` — Month Year, 7pt, --muted

VISUAL RULES

- Full slide background: --fg (#2c1f0e)
- No header band visible
- Content centered vertically at 40% from top
- Footer band present (page number + confidential)

LAYOUT_EXEC_SUMMARY `executive summary`

Use once — second slide of every deck

CONTENT FIELDS

- `insight_title` — governing thought, 22pt
- `bullets[]` — 3 to 5 items max, each with optional `semantic` color dot (success / warning / danger / none)

VISUAL RULES

- Section label "Executive summary" above bullets, 8pt, --muted, uppercase, 1pt --border rule below
- Each bullet preceded by a 5pt circle in the semantic color (--fg if none specified)
- Single column, full content width

LAYOUT_SECTION `section divider`

Use to open each major section of the deck

CONTENT FIELDS

- `section_index` — e.g. "02 / 04", 8pt, --muted
- `section_title` — 22pt, --fg, max 2 lines

VISUAL RULES

- Background: --bg-subtle (#f0ead9)
- 3pt vertical rule in --accent on the left edge of the content area
- No header band. Footer band present.
- Content vertically centered

LAYOUT_TWO_COL `two column`

Comparison, before/after, problem/solution

CONTENT FIELDS

- `insight_title` — governing thought, 22pt
- `col_left.label` — column header, 13pt, --muted, uppercase
- `col_left.bullets[]` — max 5 items, optional semantic color
- `col_right.label` + `col_right.bullets[]` — same structure

VISUAL RULES

- Columns equal width, separated by 0.5cm gutter with a 1pt --border vertical rule
- Column labels sit directly above their content with a 1pt --border rule below
- Bullets use a 2pt left-side rule in the semantic color (--border if none)

LAYOUT_STAT `stat callout`

When the key message is a number. Use for KPIs, SLOs, metrics.

CONTENT FIELDS

- `insight_title` — governing thought, 22pt
- `stats[]` — 2 to 4 items, each with: `value`, `unit`, `label`, `delta` (optional), `semantic` color (optional)

VISUAL RULES

- Each stat in a card: --bg-subtle fill, 1pt --border stroke, 0.3cm radius
- Value at 36pt in semantic color (--fg if none). Unit at 18pt, --muted.
- Label at 8pt, --muted, uppercase below value
- Delta (↑ / ↓ + text) at 8pt in --success or --danger below label
- Cards in equal-width row, 0.5cm gutter

LAYOUT_TIMELINE `timeline`

Incident timelines, roadmaps, process sequences

CONTENT FIELDS

- `insight_title` — governing thought, 22pt
- `events[]` — max 6 items, each with: `timestamp`, `description`, `semantic` color

VISUAL RULES

- Two-column grid: timestamp (right-aligned, --muted, 8pt) + description (11pt, --fg)
- Description preceded by a 2pt left rule in the semantic color of the event
- Events separated by 0.4cm vertical gap
- No horizontal divider between events

LAYOUT_RECOMMENDATION `recommendations`

Action items, next steps, proposals with owners and dates

CONTENT FIELDS

- `insight_title` — governing thought, 22pt
- `actions[]` — max 5 items, each with: `index`, `description`, `owner`, `due`, `semantic` color

VISUAL RULES

- Each action in a row: index (semantic color, 11pt, 500) + description (11pt, --fg) + owner
- due (8pt, --muted, right-aligned)
- Row background: semantic color at 8% opacity, 1pt semantic border, 0.2cm radius
- Rows separated by 0.3cm gap

LAYOUT_CLOSING `closing`

Use once — last slide of every deck

CONTENT FIELDS

- `closing_line` — e.g. "Questions & next steps", 22pt, --bg
- `contact` — email or handle, 11pt, --muted
- `deck_name` — repeated from title slide, 7pt, --muted, bottom

VISUAL RULES

- Full slide background: --fg (#2c1f0e), mirrors title slide
- 2cm × 2pt horizontal rule in --accent between closing_line and contact
- Content positioned at 45% from top, left-aligned
- deck_name at bottom left, 1.2cm from bottom edge

Layout naming convention

Layout names in the Google Slides master must match these exact strings. The Apps Script references layouts by name to instantiate them programmatically.

`LAYOUT_TITLE` `LAYOUT_EXEC_SUMMARY` `LAYOUT_SECTION` `LAYOUT_TWO_COL` `LAYOUT_STAT` `LAYOUT_TIMELINE` `LAYOUT_RECOMMENDATION` `LAYOUT_CLOSING`